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Section Title(S): MARRIAGE AND THE KINSHIP SYSTEM

When Biri was a girl, Maromo came courting, and very soon she succumbed to his charm and gave him her love token. It was to Whera she told her secret, and when, in due course, Maromo's emissary came with a hoe and a string of beads, Whera was called to the assembly of the elders. Whera it was who accepted the tokens and handed them to Biri, who fled with the beads and so shewed her shy consent.

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Later in life, when she has received a beating from Maromo, or says she has, it is again to Whera that she repairs, and by her is taken to her mother if Whera judges that she has not deserved this disciplinary treatment.

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Maromo may also consult Whera if Biri fails in her house-wifely duties. He is on excellent terms with her, and she runs out to greet him when she sees him coming, calling out "Our husbands have arrived", and takes his impedimenta, putting them in her hut. He is the honoured guest during his visit.

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Now let us look at the relationship of custom between Maromo and his mother's brother Paratema. To Paratema, Maromo is *muzukuru*, his sister's son, and he is privileged in many respects above the sons of the house. He takes precedence over them at meals, sitting next his *sekuru*, and, in a joking way, may rob him even of his raiment.⁹ As we have seen that licence is extended to some extent with Marutenga, Paratema's wife; and if Maromo exceeds its limits with her, it is she who will be blamed by Paratema, for there is a very cordial bond between *sekuru* and *muzukuru*.

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And the obligations are not one-sided. Maromo will "carry his blankets", and he will look after Paratema in sickness and in death. He is more than a son to him then. Paratema's own sons may find solace in their coming heritage.

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There may be some evidence of a vestige of the matriarchy in all this, but it is to be noted that, in matrilineal societies, the sister's son is not the favourite, as he is in a Shona group; but that father-love for sons who do not inherit is not unduly shewn towards the sister's son who does.

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Most important among Maromo's relations is his father, of course, and after him would come his elder brother (if he had one), his *mukoma* who will one day be his *baba*; and then comes  82 his father's sister Vashora, the *samukadzi*.¹⁰ It is she who will officiate at the final ceremonies after his father's death, when she will seat the heir who will succeed him as the spiritual and substantial head of the family. In this official position she may even take the title of *baba*—the father of the family—if she should survive all her brothers, until Maromo becomes in effect his father Goredema.

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⁹ In this relationship we see an exception from the rule that respect must be shewn to an older generation. The familiarity, however, is not really disrespectful. It is more in the nature of the joviality between two very good friends.

¹⁰ Her son, the *muzukuru*, is also an important person in family rites, as is the *muzukuru* of the clan.

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